The Family 35 archetype for John—final form

Wilbur N. Pickering, ThM PhD

This article is based on a complete collation of the following 63 representatives of the family for John: 18, 35, 83, 128, 141, 201, 204, 361, 363, 402, 479, 480, 510, 547, 553, 586, 685, 696, 757, 769, 789, 824, 867, 897, 928, 955, 1046, 1072, 1075, 1111, 1117, 1145, 1147, 1334, 1339, 1384, 1400, 1435, 1461, 1496, 1503, 1559, 1560, 1572, 1617, 1637, 1652, 1667, 1686, 1694, 1700, 1713, 2122, 2253, 2322, 2352, 2382, 2466, 2503, 2554, 2765 and 2948.[1]

At the seven places where there is a division of at least 10%, of the 63, I spot-checked the following **164** MSS: 55, 56, 58, 61, 66, 105, 147, 155, 167, 170, 189, 246, 285, 290, 353, 386, 387, 394, 415, 521, 575, 588, 645, 660^{s}, 664, 676, 689, 691, 758, 763, 768, 781, 797, 806, 825, 932, 938, 940, 952, 953, 958, 959, 960, 961, 962, 966, 986, 1003, 1017, 1020, 1023, 1025, 1030, 1059, 1062, 1088, 1092, 1095, 1116, 1119, 1131, 1132, 1133, 1158, 1165, 1180, 1181, 1185, 1189, 1199, 1224, 1236, 1247, 1248, 1250, 1251, 1314, 1323, 1328, 1329, 1348, 1390, 1401, 1445, 1453, 1462, 1476, 1477, 1482, 1487, 1488, 1489, 1490, 1492, 1493, 1497, 1499, 1501, 1508, 1543, 1544, 1548, 1551, 1584, 1591, 1596, 1599, 1600, 1601, 1614, 1618, 1619, 1620, 1622, 1625, 1628, 1633, 1634, 1636, 1638, 1648, 1649, 1650, 1656, 1657, 1658, 1659, 1702, 1703, 1813, 2131, 2136, 2204, 2221, 2255, 2260, 2261, (2265), 2273, 2284, 2296, 2309, 2355, 2365, 2367,2399, 2407, 2454, 2460, 2479, 2496, 2508, 2510, 2520, 2559, 2598, 2621, 2636, 2647, 2673, 2689, 2692, 2715, 2767, 2806.

Those 227 MSS represent a heavy majority of the family representatives that are presently available. I neglected a further 15 MSS that were hard to read or scrambled (the pages were bound out of order). There are at least 60 further MSS with varying amounts of mixture added to a Family 35 base (just as my model predicts). A few more family representatives may come to light, but not enough to challenge any decisions made here. Notice that the picture based on the 57 fully collated MSS remains the same after adding the 170 spot-checked MSS. My 'presently available' refers to the images that have been posted by both the INTF and the CSNTM. I say a sincere "Thank you" to both organizations.

I now discuss the divisions that were spot-checked. Only the MSS that support the minority variant (with one exception) are listed. Those within { } were spot-checked. The percentages within [ ] refer to the total of known MSS.

1:32 – εμαρτυρησεν || 1 ο [20%] 201,363,547,553,1435,1667 {147,189,290,575,660^{s},676,825,953,1236,1492,1544, 1625,1638,1813,2261,2355,2367,2407,2598,2767}

Out of the 227 MSS, 3 are missing, so out of 224 MSS (within the family) 26 have the variant, which equals 11.6%. The addition of the definite article does not affect the meaning; the translation is the same. But in any case, with less than 12% attestation, the variant is not a credible candidate. The shorter form reproduces the archetype, beyond reasonable doubt.

6:54 – αυτον 685^{c} || 1 εν [25%] 685,1339,1496,1617,1637,1700 {56,58,61,66^{c},170,189,285,290,353,660^{s},676,758, 763^{c},932,953,986,1003,1017,1095,1116,1158,1165,1180,1236,1314,1323,1329,1348,1390^{c}, 1476,1489,1499,1508,1543,1551,1591,1619,1620,1625,1634,1638,1658,1813,2131,2204,2221, 2261,2265,2309,2399,2496,2508,2598,2673,2689,2715,2767}

Out of the 227 MSS, 2 are missing, so out of 225 MSS (within the family) 60 have the variant, which equals 26.7%. Since Greek nouns and adjectives have case endings, that signal grammatical function, a preposition is often implicit in the case ending, as in this case. Making the preposition explicit affects neither the meaning nor a translation, so we have two ways of saying the same

[1] All 63 MSS I collated myself.

thing. If the longer form were original, why would anyone delete the preposition? Adding the preposition to the shorter form would be a 'natural'. But in any case, with less than 27% attestation, the variant is not a credible candidate. The shorter form reproduces the archetype, beyond reasonable doubt.

7:29 – εγω || 1 δε [30%] 141,204,547,553,897,928,1147,1334,1572,2322 {56,394,415,521,588,691,758,769,781,797, 806,962,986,1092,1119c,1133,1180,1181,1189,1247,1248,1250,1445,1477,1482,1493,1625c,1638,2204, 2261c,2273,2355,2407,2636,2692}

Out of the 227 MSS, 4 are missing, so out of 223 MSS (within the family) 42 have the variant, which equals 18.8%. The conjunction was expected, so adding it would be a 'natural'. It would make a slight difference in a translation. But in any case, with less than 19% attestation, the variant is not a credible candidate. The shorter form reproduces the archetype, beyond reasonable doubt.

8:4 – αυτοφωρω || αυτοφορω [60%] 479c,1145,1334,1559,1700,2352,2466,2048 {56,61,189,285,290,387,394,521, 664,689,691,758,763c,806,940,952,959,961,966,1017,1025,1059,1062,1131,1132, 1158,1165,1224,1247,1445,1453,1462,1476,1487,1501,1543,1591,1599,1601,1614, 1618,1622,1634,1638,1649,1656,1657,1658,1702,1813,2204,2221,2255,2260,2309, 2399,2559,2598,2621,2635,2689,2692,2715}

Out of the 227 MSS, 1 is missing, so out of 226 MSS (within the family) 69 have the variant, which equals 30.5%. But in any case, a mere alternate spelling is not a proper variant, since neither the identity nor the meaning of the word is affected. The shorter form reproduces the archetype, beyond reasonable doubt.

11:21 – ουν || 1 η [40%] 141,204,363,553,928,1147,1334,1572,1667,2322 {290,394,521,660s,691,758,769,797,806, 953,986,1017,1020,1092,1116,1133,1158,1181,1189,1199,1247,1248,1250,1314,1445,1477,1482, 1493,1497,1622,1656c,2136,2204,2261c,2284,2296,2355,2407,2692,2715}

Out of the 227 MSS, 4 are missing, so out of 223 MSS (within the family) 48 have the variant, which equals 21.1%. The addition of the definite article does not affect the meaning; the translation is the same. But in any case, with less than 22% attestation, the variant is not a credible candidate. The shorter form reproduces the archetype, beyond reasonable doubt.

12:6 – εμελεν 18,141,201,204,363c,402,479,480,553c,685c,789c,928,1072c,1075,1111c,1334,1339,1384,1461,1496,1503, 1572,1667,2253,2322,2382c,2503,2554 {55,58,61,66,285,361c,386,691,758,763,769,938c,940,955,959, 1030c,1132,1189,1247,1390c,1400,1445,1482,1492,1493,1499,1544,1548,1599,1600c,1619,1620,1625,1638, 1648,1650,1656c,1702,1813,2131, 2136,2221,2260,2284,2496,2559,2598,2621,2635,2636,2692,2806}

εμελλεν [60%] 35,83,128,363,510,547,553,575,586,685,696,757,789,824,867,897,1072,1111,1117, 1145,1147, 1435,1559,1560,1617,1637,1652,1686,1694,1700,1713,2352,2382,2466,2765,l.2110 {56,105,147,155,170, 189,246,290,353,361,387,394,415,521,588,645,660s,664,676,689,758c,768,781,797,806,825,932,938,952, 953,958,960,961,962,966,986,1003,1017,1020,1023,1030,1025,1046,1059,1062,1088,1092,1095,1116,1119, 1131,1133,1158,1165,1180,1181,1185,1199,1224,1236,1248,1250,1251,1314,1323,1328,1329,1348,1390, 1401,1453,1462,1476,1477,1488,1489,1490,1497,1499c,1501,1508,1543,1548,1551,1591,1596,1600,1601, 1614,1618,1622,1628,1633,1634,1636,1638,1649,1656,1657,1703,1813,2204,2255,2260,2261,2265,2273, 2296,2355,2367,2407,2454,2479,2508,2510,2647,2673,2689,2715,2767}

As is typical of variation within the family, the difference is of one letter. However, in this case that one letter changes the verb! Is the verb μελω or μελλω? μελει as an impersonal form is most common; however the verb is also used in a personal/active sense. μελλω ('to be about to') simply does not make sense here. μελλω is about ten times as frequent in the NT and some copyists may have put the more customary spelling without thinking. They had just written μελλων two lines above and may have repeated the form by attraction. However, since both forms have the same

pronunciation, someone hearing the Text read aloud would understand it correctly, being guided by the context. Someone reading to himself would do the same. Precisely for this reason, it may be that the semantic area of the longer form came to be regarded as including that of the shorter form; in which case we would have alternate spellings of the same verb. It is not my custom to appeal to the early uncials, but all of them—$P^{66,75}$,א,A,B,D,Q,W—have the shorter form here, which would go along with my hypothesis above. In spite of the lopsided attestation, since the central meaning of the longer form cannot be correct, being nonsense, I conclude that the first form reproduces the archetype, beyond reasonable doubt.

18:39 – ημιν || υμιν [80%] 928,1334,1572,1667,1700 {56,58,61,66,105,147,167,189,285,290,353,387,394,588,660^s, 676,691,758,768,825,932,952,953,966,986,1003,1017,1095,1165,1180,1181,1185,1224,1236,1247, 1248,1250,1323,1329,1348,1445,1476,1477,1482,1497,1622,1625,1633,1648,1703,1813,2136,2204, 2221,2260,2261,2265,2284,2296,2479,2496,2508,2598,2673,2692,2715}

Out of the 227 MSS, 16 are missing, so out of 211 MSS (within the family) 71 have the variant, which equals 33.6%. Really now, would Rome release a prisoner based on a Jewish demand? This was evidently a bit of 'pub. rel.' that Rome had decided to do. Since the second person dominated the transmission outside the family, for whatever reason, that may have influenced some copyists. As usual, the difference is one letter, and both vowels were pronounced the same way, adding to the confusion. In any case, 33.6% attestation is not enough to warrant a change. I conclude that the first form reproduces the archetype, beyond reasonable doubt.

That completes the discussion of the seven places where there is a division of at least 10%. As is typical of variation within the family, there is very little difference in meaning between the options. As I have demonstrated, we are able to affirm the precise form of the family archetype for the whole book of John, beyond reasonable doubt. It is reproduced in my Greek Text, *The Greek New Testament according to Family 35*. Should someone prefer one or more of the alternates, it remains true that none of the text has been lost; it is one or the other. I maintain that the family archetype has been perfectly preserved, but in any case, it has been completely preserved: no wording has been lost.

I will now consider the force of the evidence chapter by chapter, simply counting the MSS, but due consideration needs to be given to the discussion of the divisions, above. Mere alternate spellings should be discounted, and so on.

Chapter 1: No variant has more than six MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 35 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 7 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter one.

Chapter 2: No variant has more than five MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 37 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 7 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter two.

Chapter 3: No variant has more than five MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 31 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 11 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter three.

Chapter 4: No variant has more than four MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 31 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will

doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 11 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter four.

Chapter 5: No variant has more than four MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 34 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 8 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter five.

Chapter 6: No variant has more than six MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 22 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 16 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter six.

Chapter 7: No variant has more than ten MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 30 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 8 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter seven.

Chapter 8: No variant has more than seven MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 29 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 16 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter eight.

Chapter 9: No variant has more than three MSS. Of the 56 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 42 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 9 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter nine.

Chapter 10: No variant has more than three MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 34 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 12 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter ten.

Chapter 11: No variant has more than ten MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 23 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 7 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter eleven.

Chapter 12: No variant has more than thirty-five MSS (please read the discussion of the division in 12:6). Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), only 11 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter. However, the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 7 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter twelve.

Chapter 13: No variant has more than two MSS. Of the 56 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 34 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 11 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter thirteen.

Chapter 14: No variant has more than three MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 38 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 5 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter fourteen.

Chapter15: No variant has more than two MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 43 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 10 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter fifteen.

Chapter 16: No variant has more than five MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 38 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 10 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter sixteen.

Chapter 17: No variant has more than three MSS. Of the 57 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 46 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 4 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter seventeen.

Chapter 18: No variant has more than five MSS. Of the 56 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 33 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 5 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter eighteen.

Chapter 19: No variant has more than two MSS. Of the 54 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 27 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 18 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter nineteen.

Chapter 20: No variant has more than three MSS. Of the 53 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 37 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 7 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter twenty.

Chapter 21: No variant has more than two MSS. Of the 54 collated MSS (complete, or nearly so), 37 are perfect representatives of the archetype in this chapter, and the MSS yet to be collated will doubtless add many more. If we disregard singular readings (within the family), we add 15 more. It follows that we know the precise archetypal form of chapter twenty-one.

Conclusion: I have demonstrated empirically that we know the precise archetypal form of Family 35, for the book of John, based on the available evidence. **God has preserved His Text!**